Singh, had told Bowles that the prime minister's position remained the same—India was not developing nuclear weapons—and India would let the US know if anything changed.[210]

By spring 1965, however, US intelligence analysts had asserted that if India did not have an international security guarantee, it was more than likely that it would go for the bomb.[211] Another Chinese test in May had only heightened this possibility. However, in Washington, concerns about giving India such a guarantee—alone or with others—had persisted. Ambassador at Large Llewellyn Thompson had been concerned that Bowles had been indicating to Indian officials that the US was willing to offer India a specific guarantee. He and others had reservations about such a guarantee, especially a joint one with the Soviet Union.[212] Bowles had wanted Washington to think about "parallel action" with Moscow at least.[213] Thompson, in turn, had suggested offering some other kind of assurance, but something that kept "freedom of action" in US hands.[214]

That attitude and the implication about US reliability, however, was another reason that India had little desire to pursue a guarantee solely from the US. The subsequent 1965 war did little to alleviate concerns about the reliability of external benefactors. At the onset of the war Rusk had indeed predicted, "If the Chicoms get involved or this conflict runs its present course … India, feeling let down by the West and its national prestige at stake, would almost certainly go for the nuclear bomb."[215]

An October 1965 US intelligence assessment noted that the war had indeed strengthened the hands of the advocates of a nuclear weapons program. However, it had also strengthened Shastri, who did not want to nuclearize, and his greater domestic political capital allowed him to hold off these calls. Nonetheless, the assessment expected the policy to change and predicted that "within the next few years India probably will detonate a nuclear device and proceed to develop nuclear weapons."[216] There was little expectation that India would give up its nuclear option.[217]

There was even less expectation that China would rest on its laurels, and both the US and India sought to keep an eye on developments in its nuclear program. This shared interest led to a joint operation that could have been scripted in Bollywood or Hollywood. The two countries' intelligence agencies cooperated to try to place a nuclear-powered device in the Himalayas to monitor Chinese nuclear activity. The first expedition in